

To be coded as a causal explainer for a feature, at least one of the free responses provided in training must have contained a) a reference to the visual feature in question and b) an explanation for why that particular feature would affect the outcome. For instance, using an example of a stimulus not used in this experiment, “A giraffe's long neck allows it to reach more food” would count as a causal explanation because it cites a) the long neck and b) the reason why that feature contributes to an outcome.

In order to count as an explanation, the description cannot only use a synonym for the outcome in question. For instance, ‘Long necks mean producing more offspring’ would not be sufficient to be coded as a causal explanation, because ‘produce more offspring’ is just a synonym for fertility. On the other hand, ‘Long necks are more attractive to mates’ would count as one, since the latter cites a mechanism implicitly (attraction) whereas the former simply states that the feature is linked to the outcome.

Another example: saying ‘a curly tail would be favored because it leads animals to consume more’ is not a causal explanation, because ‘consume more’ is just another way of saying ‘eats more’. However ‘a curly tail would be favored because it requires more energy’ would be, because ‘energy’ implies the feature is playing some explanatory role in higher energy expenditure.